

Order Passeriformes continued

Family Hirundinidae

Swallows and martins

Length 4¾–9 in (12–23 cm)

Species 88



Found all around the world, except in the frozen Arctic and Antarctic regions, swallows and martins are often dark blue or green above and paler below. Most have a forked tail, and some have long tail streamers. The bill is short but has a wide gape that is an effective

trap for catching insects on the wing. Their dependence on aerial insects makes many species migrants—they breed in temperate areas but fly to the tropics and south temperate areas when the weather gets colder and insect prey disappears. However, many species live in the tropics throughout the year. Swallows and martins have 3 types of nests: natural holes in trees, cliffs, or buildings; tunnels excavated in river banks or sand quarries; and mud cups attached to cliffs or buildings. Some species raise 2 or 3 broods, the clutch size ranging from one to 8 eggs.

CLIFF SWALLOW
Petrochelidon pyrrhonota
breeds from Alaska to Mexico and winters in South America. About 13–15 cm (5–6 in) long, it nests colonially, building gourd-shaped mud nests under the eaves of a building or on a cliff. The female lays 4–6 white eggs.



blue-black male

PURPLE MARTIN
Progne subis nests in man-made martin houses and in old woodpecker holes in trees. Colonies can number up to 200 pairs. About 7 in (18 cm) long, it breeds in North America and winters in the Amazon Basin. The male is blue-black all over, but the female is duller above and pale gray below.



COMMON HOUSE MARTIN
Delichon urbicum winters in Africa (south of the Sahara) and Southeast Asia. It builds mud half-cup nests on walls under eaves of buildings, where it nests in groups. This bird is 5 in (12.5 cm) in length.



2 long tail streamers

BARN SWALLOW
A summer visitor to North America, North Africa, Europe, and Asia, *Hirundo rustica* winters in Africa south of the Sahara, and in southern Asia, Australia, and South America. It is 7 in (18 cm) long. A lively singer, its nest is a mud half-cup, often on a beam in farm outbuildings. It lays 4–6 red-spotted, white eggs.

BROWN-THROATED MARTIN
This martin is resident in Morocco and widespread south of the Sahara in Africa, usually near inland wetlands. *Riparia paludicola* is about 5 in (13 cm) long, and most have a white belly but some are entirely brown. It forms very large flocks.



Family Macrosphenidae

Crombecs and African warblers

Length 3–9 in (8–23 cm)

Species 19



This is a varied group of insectivorous warblers and allies, some resembling Eurasian counterparts, others unique to Africa. Crombecs, for example, are small, rounded, almost tailless bush warblers with slim, downcurved bills, and are variably greenish or more patterned with gray and orange. Mixed groups can occur, often one species feeding higher in the tree canopy than another, foraging methodically through foliage for insects and seeds. They make rather large, pouchlike nests of grasses slung from a low twig. Longbills, with their short tails; stubby bodies; and long, slender

bills, also feed in the canopy or bushes, while others, such as the Cape grassbird, have different, more specialized habitat requirements. The distinctive reddish brown, black, and white rockrunner is most unlike the others in its preference for rocks and arid scree slopes.

LONG-BILLED CROMBEC
Both sexes and juveniles of this typical gray-and-orange species of crombec all look much alike.



Family Cettiidae

Cettia bush warblers

Length 5–6 in (13–14 cm)

Species 32



A small group of warblers, these are characterized by rather dark coloration; rounded wings; and broad, rounded tails. They live close to the ground, sometimes going higher in dense shrubbery from which they may sing, but usually remaining in more or less waterlogged or dense thickets. Their loud songs are easy to hear, but they are hard birds to see well; the song may suddenly be repeated from another place entirely, the bird having slipped through dense vegetation unobserved. The song helps defend a territory and attract more than one female. Males have little or no role in rearing the young.

CETTI'S WARBLER
This species spread northward in Europe a few decades before climate change. The impact was expected, but it has proven sensitive to cold winters.

